



Evergreen presence: P. R. Sreejesh's reassuring presence in the goalpost has been a sight for the sore eyes.

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Sreejesh was the saviour in the third-place match against Germany in Tokyo, where India secured an Olympic medal after 41 years. Three years later, he thwarted Spain's late charge to secure another bronze in Paris. A player who continuously evolved throughout his career, Sreejesh urged the younger generation to learn from the struggles of past hockey players and to appreciate the current success.

"We fought, faced obstacles, and overcame countless hurdles. Now, we have victory. For young kids, this is a lesson. You can't become an Olympian overnight. You can't become an Olympic medalist overnight. It took me nearly 21 years to stand on that podium. For many of them, they achieved it on their

first attempt. I want to tell them to be patient, keep working hard, and believe in the process. In the end, you will find yourself on the podium."

This golden advice stems from his deep passion and love for the sport. The way he prostrated before the goalpost and then perched on it, as he did in Tokyo, painted the picture of a king with his throne.

The goalpost, his good friend and emotional anchor, symbolizes Sreejesh's journey through a match. "You need to let go of your frustration. So, when you talk to the goalposts, when you're abusive, when you control every emotion, it helps you get back to normal. Sometimes, I even sing to my

goalposts."

As Indian hockey's beloved goalkeeper Sreejesh calls it a day, Hockey India has decided to retire his iconic No. 16 jersey while also tapping into his vast expertise. He has been appointed head coach of the junior men's team, where he will mentor the next generation of players, ensuring a smooth transition and laying a strong foundation for the national team's success in upcoming tournaments like the 2026 World Cup and the 2028 Olympics.

If the new crop of players imbibes even a part of Sreejesh's steely resolve and never-say-die attitude, Indian hockey will be better for it.

« Sreejesh is likely to be tasked with mentoring the next generation of goalkeepers »